
Sustainable impact as an outcome

Before you conclude and evaluate your project, it is important to ensure its future sustainability. By building lasting relationships and embracing strategies like *'relay learning'*, the outcomes of your project can live on, resulting in a real impact.

Within transdisciplinary projects, you aim to create impact through a rich collaboration between various parties—this provides the best chance for an appropriate outcome or solution. However, changes don't happen overnight. Multiple outcomes, both visible and invisible, need to evolve over time to achieve transformation. Since projects typically have a relatively short duration (ranging from one to ten weeks, or perhaps a year), you need to think about sustainable ways to use, preserve, and further develop the collected knowledge, products, and skills.

Sustainable relationships

Sustainable relationships are key to sustainable impact. For instance, if you conduct a project with students, researchers, and residents in a specific

neighbourhood, it can be harmful to only be present for a short period and then leave – this is likely to be a so-called ‘exploitive relationship’.

However, if a teacher, researcher, or facilitator works with the same neighbourhood over a longer period, a better understanding of the area can be developed and a trust relationship between the residents and the project can be built. The need for longer relationships can also exist between project participants, such as students and community partners. Community partners in particular, may be in a position to invite students for long-term collaboration.

‘Relay learning’

To avoid superficial outcomes based on short-term collaboration, the concept of *‘relay learning’* offers a good solution. This means that a transdisciplinary team continues to work on the outcome delivered by a previous team. This approach allows them to understand and tackle the complex problem in a well-founded manner. This is a form of collaboration between different teams, albeit not simultaneously. When choosing this model, it is important to carefully transfer the information, knowledge, or actions that have been previously created.